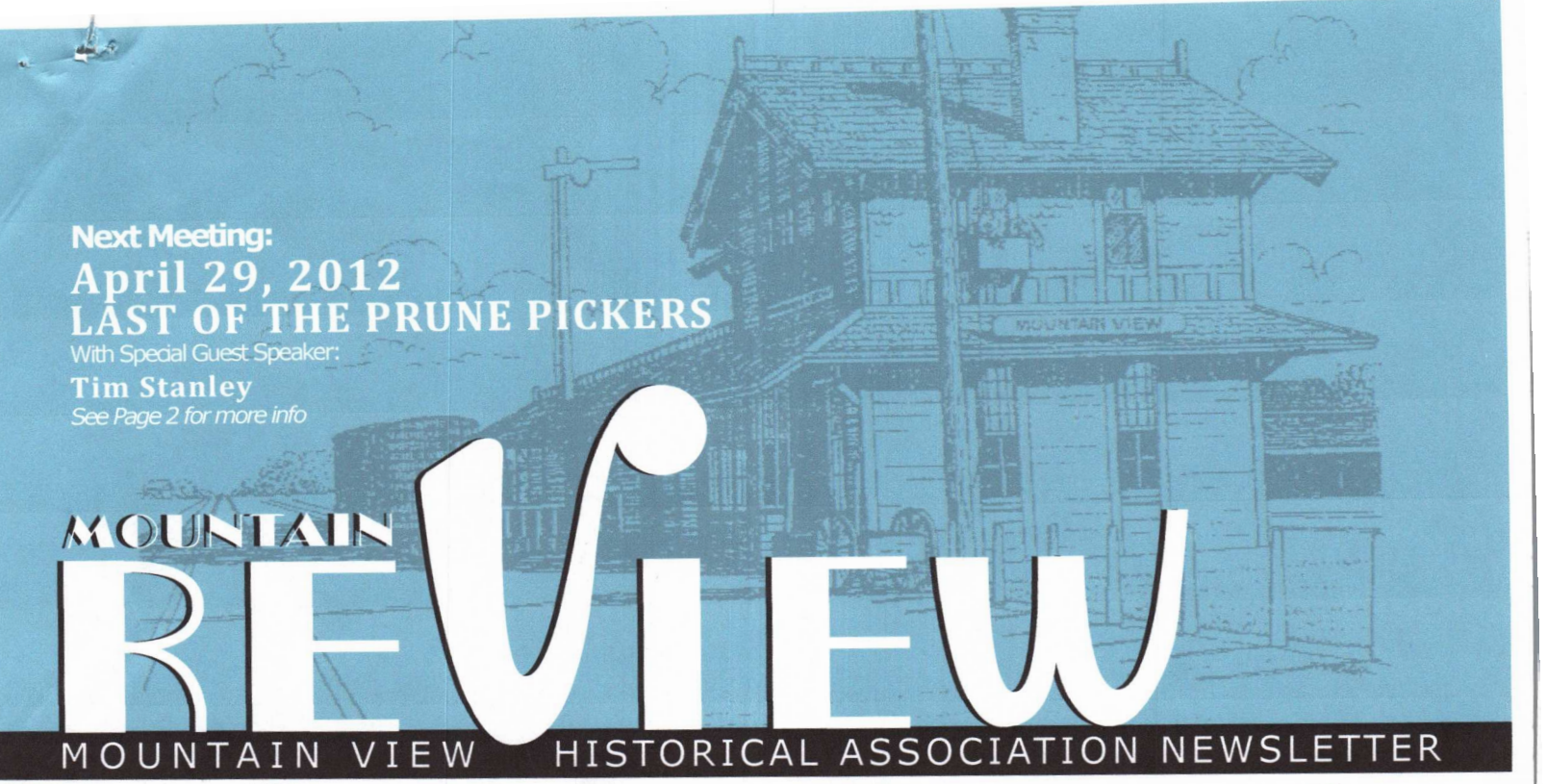


Next Meeting:
April 29, 2012
LAST OF THE PRUNE PICKERS
With Special Guest Speaker:
Tim Stanley
See Page 2 for more info

MOUNTAIN REVIEW

MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION NEWSLETTER

Volume II ***Issue 2*** ***Spring 2012***

HIGHLIGHTS

Mtn. View Memories



Memories of a Mountain View Prune Picker
Page 5

New Section! *On the Web*



Read what people remember when we post some of MVHA's historic photos to the web
Page 6

CONTENTS

News & Notes	2
Street Talk	4
Mtn. View Memories	5
On the Web	6
Membership	7
Winter Events	8



President's Message

By Patricia Figueroa
MVHA President

Hi Everyone,

Mark your calendar! - It's time for next Quarterly Membership Meeting, which has been moved up one week, and will be held on Sunday April 29th.

I wanted to give you an update of some of the actions taken at our last Board meeting held on March 14th. The Audit Committee submitted their annual report, and I am pleased to share with you that they found everything to be in excellent order. We also established a Membership Committee to begin a review of our Membership Dues and annual membership renewal process. We want to make sure that we have in place a Membership renewal process that is easy and timely. If you have any suggestions you want to share with the Membership Committee please let me know.The Board also decided that we needed to make more of an effort to become more visible at Community Events held downtown by having a table distributing our Brochures. The Board would welcome the support of others when we do these projects so when you see a sign-up sheet from us asking for volunteers remember your one or two hours are extremely valuable to us.

Hope some of you are taking the time to checkout our Facebook page (facebook.com/mvhistory). Some slides of the 1960s were recently found and have been digitized and some of them put on our Facebook page. You would enjoy seeing how these photos make others recall so many fond memories. One photo is of the area in front of the "Menu Tree" – someone said "a place before it's time" and they were probably right. My family remembers the many meals we had under "the clock" inside the Menu Tree.

See you on April 29th!

Pat Figueroa
(650)965-4783
patfig@ix.netcom.com



MOUNTAIN VIEW REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, Ca 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

BOARD MEMBERS & CHAIRS

President: Patricia Figueroa
Vice-President: Cliff Del Carlo
Secretary: Jamil Shaikh
Treasurer: John Figueroa
Past President: Bob Weaver
Historical Data: Barbara Kinchen
Membership: June Casey
Newsletter Editor: Nick Perry
Ways & Means: Richard Espinosa
Director-at Large: Nick Galiotto
Hospitality: Helene Hughes
Memorial & Remembrances: Trudi Tuban
Programs: Bob Weaver
Publicity: Jes Casey

Become a Member Today!

See Page 7 on how to join!

In Memoriam

Margaret Peterson
Former MVHA Secretary
February 3, 2012

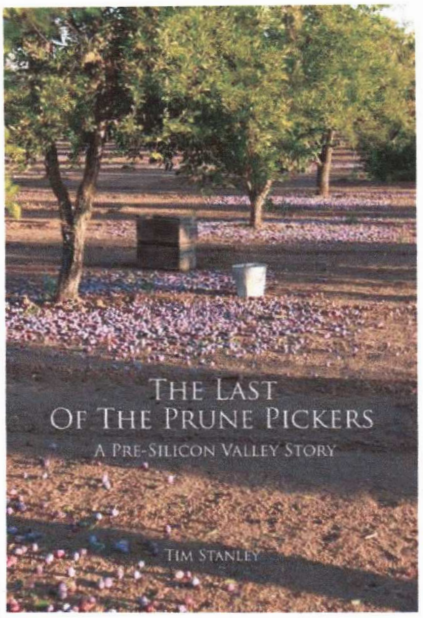
John P. Tomac
Former Mtn. View Police Captain
January 25, 2012

Faye Taylor
June 13, 2011

News & Notes

Spring Meeting Preview

By Bob Weaver
Past President and Programs Chair



Not long before the Santa Clara Valley of California was known for silicon, the Valley was largely covered with orchards. There were orchards of pears, apricots, cherries, walnuts and the king of them all—prunes. Most of the orchards were part of small family farms, and there were thousands of them. This is the story of how those farms came into being and thrived. It is also the story of one of the last of those farms, of the farmer and of some of the young boys and girls who had the privilege of working for him.

We were among the last of the prune pickers.

Tim Stanley grew up in Saratoga, and during his teens worked on one of the last fruit farms there. When he married, he and his wife moved to Los Gatos and later to Irvine. After running a construction business for thirty years, Tim is now working as a free-lance writer. He has published a local history book titled, ***The Last of the Prune Pickers: A Pre-Silicon Valley Story***. His web site is: www.2timothypublishing.com

Mr. Stanley will give a brief overview of the book with visual aid. He will divide the presentation into two parts: the Historical Background for the orchard farms that once graced the Santa Clara Valley and the Way of Life of the orchard farmers.

The Historical Background presentation will include a little about Mission Santa Clara agricultural operations, the Californios and cattle ranching, early American farming successes and failures, and highlights of the technology stories that transformed the Valley into "The Garden of the World."In the Way of Life presentation, Mr. Stanley will discuss orchard farming, market challenges and the Sunsweet story, the end of the orchard era, and some lessons learned.

Mr. Stanley has traveled a great distance to speak with us, and others who have heard him speak have found him quite entertaining. Please don't forget that our spring meeting will be one week earlier than usual, April 29, so double check your calendars as you won't want to miss this program. Mr. Stanley will have a few books available for sale at our meeting.

MVHA Spring Membership Meeting - Sunday April 29, 2012 at 2:00pm
The Adobe Building - Moffett Blvd. & Central Expressway
Parking in the rear off Central Avenue.

New to the History Center

By Barbara Kinchen
Historical Data Chair

- From Bob Weaver: CD of 2002 Arbor Day Celebration and Dedication of Fire Station #2

- From Tom Chamblis: 1932-33 Directory of Santa Clara county Rural Routes (mail). Names, route and box numbers, road or street are listed and other interesting information. Included are occupations, owner or renter, acres owned, and if any of the following is owned by the household: electric power, pumping plant, tractor, truck, automobile, radio, washing machine, electric refrigerator or electric range. Everyone seems to have electricity, but very few own washing machines, refrigerators or ranges.

Financial Report

By John Figueroa
Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 12/7/11: $ 8,897.32
- Income: $ 953.52
- Expenses: $ 676.52
- Checking Account Balance as of 3/14/12: $ 9,174.32

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 12/7/11: $82,023.62
Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 3/14/12: $82,259.62
- Including $ 31,255.61 designated for the Museum.

Rengstorff House Events

By Kristina Perino
City of Mountain View Senior Recreation Coordinator

The City of Mountain View's Shoreline Division is pleased to announce its next exhibition at the historic Rengstorff House, entitled "From Horse & Buggy to the Model T: Turn of the Century Transportation, Then and Now."

Featuring photos of scow schooners, livery stables, wagons, stagecoaches, electric cars (from nearby towns/cities), early railroad scenes and more, the exhibit will also include modern-day, color photographs of vintage automobiles, in partnership with the Santa Clara Horseless Carriage Club and Santa Clara Valley Model T Ford Club. The exhibit runs May 20 through July 25, on public tour days of Tuesdays, Wednesdays and Sundays from 11:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m.

Members of the MVHA are also encouraged to also visit the house on Sunday, July 24 from 2:30 – 4:30 pm, as on this day, the City will host a "meet and greet" with participating vintage car owners. We expect to have approximately 10-15 cars on display in the parking lot for the public to enjoy.

The Rengstorff House is Mountain View's oldest home and one of the West Coast's finest examples of Victorian Italianate architecture on the West Coast. If you wish to schedule a group tour at any time, please contact Senior Recreation Coordinator Kristina Perino at (650) 903-6088.

Visit the History Center

The Mountain View History Center's mission is to collect, organize and make available Mountain View historical resources and to promote the city's heritage. It contains the historic archives of both the Mountain View Historical Association and the Mountain View Public Library. Historical books and pamphlets on the history of Mountain View are also available for purchase at the History Center.

Location:
Mountain View Public Library, 2nd Floor
585 Franklin Street
Mountain View, CA 94041

Hours:
The history center is open to the general public from 1-5pm every Tuesday and by appointment.

Call 650-903-6890 for more information.

VICTORIAN PLAY DAY

Sunday, May 20th
2:00 to 5:00 PM

Rengstorff House
Shoreline at Mountain View
www.r-house.org
Hands-on Play Day
Free Fun for All Ages



Go Green!
See the Newsletter in
FULL COLOR

Save paper and resources by e-mailing us at *mvha.newsletter@gmail.com* to receive the newsletter as an Adobe PDF.

Street Talk

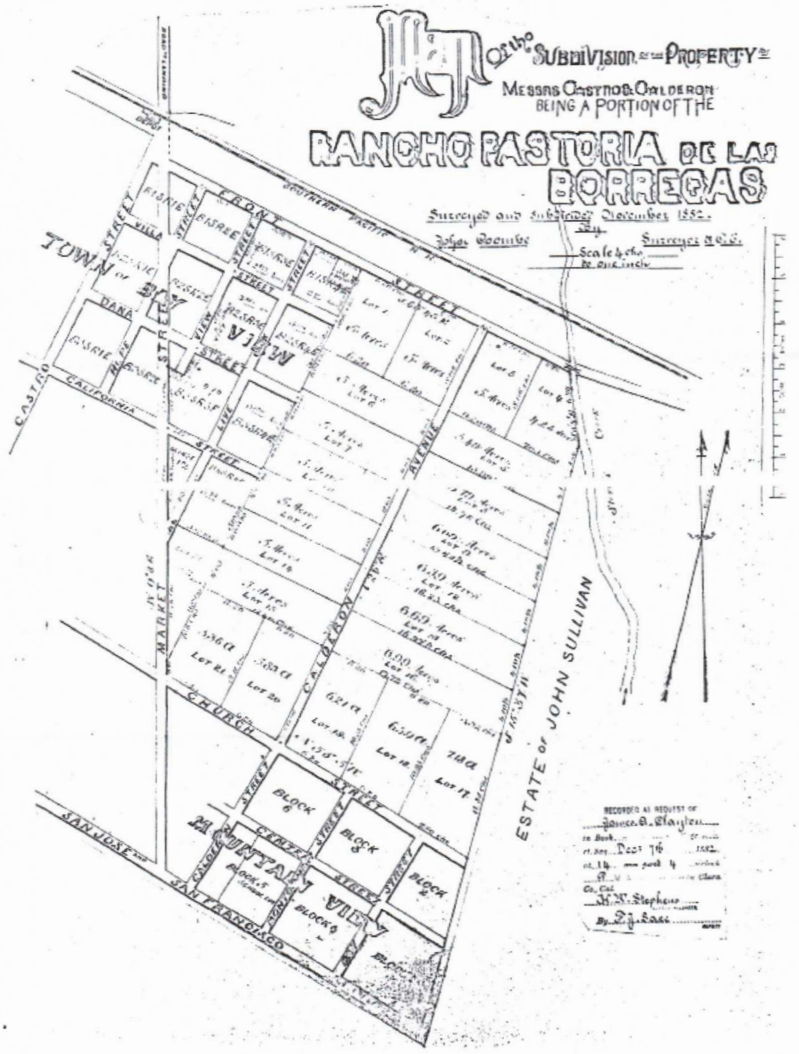
Abate Industrial SQ 100

By Barbara Kinchen
Historical Data Chair

In the March newsletter of the Old Mountain View Neighborhood Association, Robert Cox gives the names for the four "private" streets in the housing development being built at Evelyn and Calderon Avenues (formerly Abates Industrial Square.) Two names echo San Francisco streets - Geary Way and Pine Way. And two use names of previous owners of the property - Abate Street and Francesca Court. Several generations of the Abate family have lived and operated businesses at this busy corner. Directories beginning in the 1940s show they operated a machine shop and welding shops. The 1954 Directory lists Abate Brothers Gunsmiths.

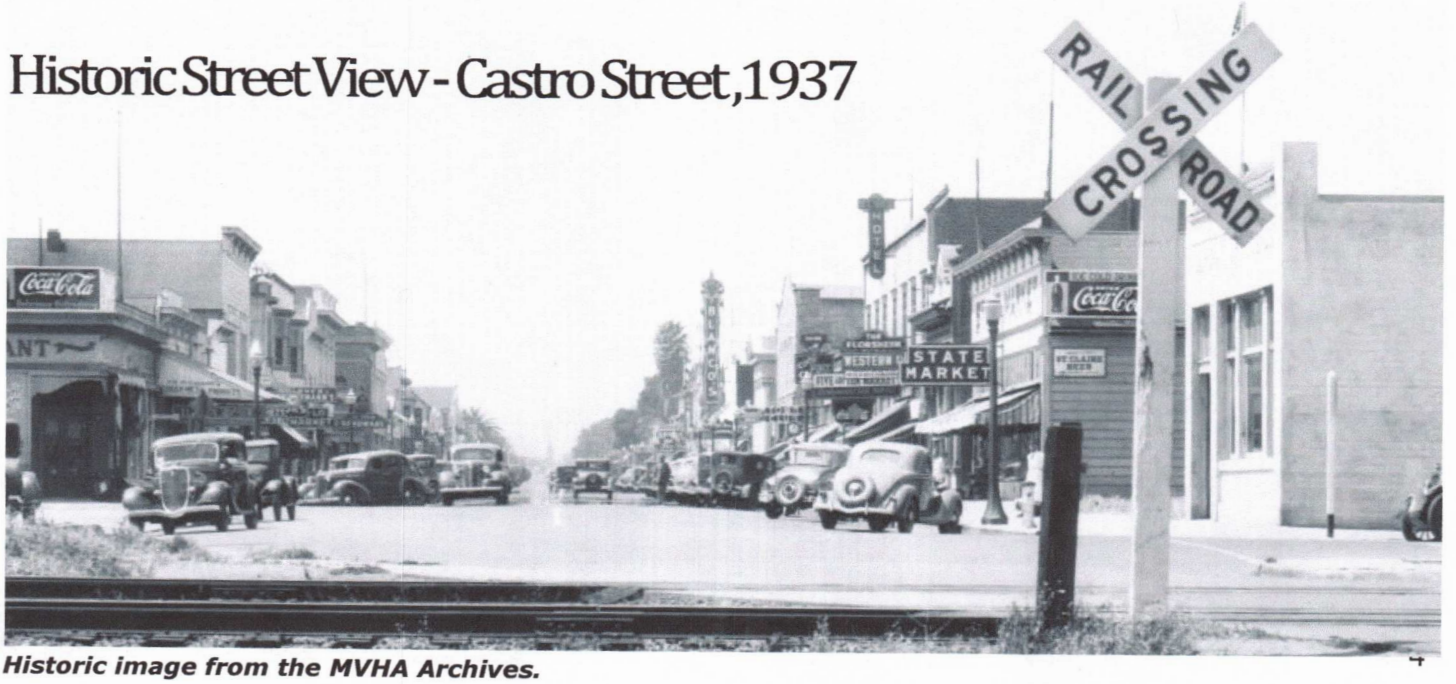
Francesca (sometimes Francisca) Castro was wife of Crisanto Castro, whose last home, built in 1911, was named Villa Francesca. The location was our present Rengstorff Park. The Castro family owned thousands of acres, including the Mountain View area since 1845.

An 1882 map shows a portion of Castro holdings, including Calderon Avenue. In 1883 A.M. Stoddard bought all 21 lots totaling some 117 acres, for $11,837. Records show the properties sold in 1885. Briefly Calderon Avenue was called Stoddard Avenue, but soon took back the former name which honors Crisanto's sister, Mrs. Mercedes Castro de Calderon.



A c. 1882 proposed subdivision map of Mountain View showing lots along Calderon Avenue. The Abate property was located on the southwest corner of Calderon Avenue and Front Street (now Evelyn avenue) ***Image Courtesy Mountain View History Center***

Historic Street View - Castro Street, 1937



Historic image from the MVHA Archives.

Mtn. View Memories

Share your Mtn. View Memories!
E-mail short stories (less than one page) to mvha.newsletter@gmail.com or send them to 1546 W. Dana St. Mtn. View CA 94041
We look forward to your submissions!



Young MV Prune Pickers: Warren Goff, Nolan, Eugene, and David Sharp, Harry Goff, and Sylvia Sharp. In front of the great oak tree at El Ranchito Avenue behind the Sharp home.

Memories of a MV Prune Picker

By Eugene Darrell Sharp
MVHA Member

In August of 1947 I picked my first prunes at the orchards of Ernest and Fanny Powell on the corner of Alma Street (now Central Expressway) and Rengstorff Avenue. The Powells were members of the Trinity Methodist Church, which my family also attended. There were about 10 acres of orchard on their property; over one-half were prune trees along with a few plum trees next to Alma. The apricot trees were on the other side of the long driveway from Rengstorff to the Powell home.

On a Monday morning early in August I biked to work through town on Villa Street. I passed the Castro home (Villa Francesca) and I biked across the railroad tracks on Rengstorff and into the Powell driveway. I took two buckets into the orchard, kneeled down in the soft smooth dirt and started picking prunes with both hands. I usually had one foot on the ground in front of me so that I could rest my chest on my knee. It was easy to advance by moving the other foot forward and resting the other side of my chest on the other knee. I usually ate several prunes when I started picking. Having grown up on a farm west of Eaton Colorado there was something very satisfying about being in that wonderful Santa Clara Valley dirt.

Mr. Powell would precede us by shaking the tree branches to increase the number of prunes on the ground. I carried the two buckets heaped with prunes and poured them into the lugs nearby. I could usually pick about 20 lugs of prunes a day at 20 cents a box. I earned about $50 that August, the first money that I ever earned. I opened a savings account at the Bank of America on the corner of Castro and Villa Streets and put almost all of my earnings there. The bank building now houses the Red Rock Cafe. I picked prunes at the Powell's for three of four years.

At noon I ate the lunch my mother made for me and would watch Mr. Powell pour a lug box into a wire basket at the end of a 20-foot four-inch diameter wooden pole. The pole was suspended in the middle about eight feet above ground. Mr. Powell would then take the far end of the pole and lift the basket into a tub containing boiling lye (NaOH.) After maybe 30 seconds, he would lift the basket, let the lye drain for a minute and rotate the basket above a drying tray so that he could pour the prunes onto the tray and smooth them in one layer. The boiling hot lye bath broke the skins of the prunes so that they would dry in the sun and not spoil. About a week later, the prunes would be ready to sell. I imagine that the lye never bothered any prune eater, because the sugars in the prunes and the slightly acidic prune skins would neutralize the lye.

My cousins Warren and Harry, and their mother, Eva Mae Goff, came to visit several summers. They stayed with my grandparents in a former field office—still standing on El Ranchito Way—that my father used to supervise the installation of the Westinghouse equipment at the 40 by 80 NASA Wind Tunnel. We picked prunes at the Popovich orchard at the southern boundary between Mountain View and Sunnyvale on El Camino Real. Warren and Harry joined me and my siblings Nolan and Sylvia Sharp picking prunes there. I was docked pay for a box of prunes because I picked some worthless prunes that every one else said were no good.

I also picked prunes with a couple of buddies: Dickie Eglington and Ubaldo Maxwelliano St. Jovenine Tonella. We biked out Grant Road across the railroad tracks (now Foothill Expressway) where we often paused to lay one of our bikes across the tracks to cause the wig wags and red light to flash. A pickup truck stopped to wait for the coming train. When the driver saw us young punks, he shook his head and crossed the tracks. We picked prunes and goofed off, pissing into the smudge pots, and had lunch sitting in an oak tree on Fremont Avenue. We watched the steam engine stop to take on water from a tank next to the track. We went to get paid at a home next to the Boy Scout Hall, a former fire house, next to the home where Louise and Will Jordan lived for a time on the Hope and Villa corner. The former Boy Scout House is now a MV parking lot and the two houses at 191 Hope Street are now dental offices.

With all the summer work in the orchards there was no time to get into mischief.

On the Web

In this new occasional feature we will share some of the best comments, memories and stories shared by "fans" of the Mountain View Historical Association's facebook page. To join the conversation on-line, visit: www.facebook.com/MVHistory

We shared this c. 1966 image of the old San Antonio Mall & Menu Tree Restaurant entry:



...and here's what people are saying:

"I loved the Menu Tree. A great concept ahead of its time."

"I loved the Menu Tree! My mom and I ate there a lot. Wonder what ever happened to all the birds..."

"I loved the Menu Tree too! We used to eat there every Sunday after church."

"We would walk from our house on Stanford Ave a lot."

the MENU TREE

"I worked at the Menu Tree..."

"This picture is facing towards where Mervyns used to be at...I remember the colorful birds at the menu tree..."

"Only knew this as it is today, just cannot believe that this area ever looked like this!! Where is the rising smoke in the background coming from??"

"The smoke is probably coming from Sondgroth Brothers Construction (Later Freeman`Sondgroth?). They had some sort of construction/industrial facility where The Old Mill eventually went in."

Membership

Membership Report

By June Casey
Membership Chair

6/8/12 Pat

Membership as of March 20, 2012

Honored Members	HM	1	2
Life Members	LM	120	117 116
Family Members	AF	148	54 56
Single Members	AS		111 110
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP		269	**284**
		−15?	
		254	

- New Life Member: Craig Norris

Old Labels show 243
14×17
+5

Join us today!

The Mountain View Historical Association welcomes new members. Any person who signifies interest in the aims of the Association and who pays the specified annual dues may become a member.

The aims of the MVHA are:

- To gather and preserve historical data relative to the early settlement and development of the area in and around the present City of Mountain View.
- To collect, record, edit and publish a history of the pioneering activities of this area
- To preserve historic objects and places
- To cooperate with other organizations in the Santa Clara Valley on projects deemed worthy by our membership

MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Membership Application & Renewal Form

- ☐ New membership
- ☐ Renewal

SINGLE?

- ☐ REGULAR MEMBER: *$10/year*
- ☐ FAMILY MEMBER: *$15/year*
- ☐ LIFE TIME MEMBER: *$200*
- ☐ *Contact me for Volunteer opportunities*

NAME: _____

ADDRESS: _____

_____

CITY: _____ ZIP

TELEPHONE _____

E-MAIL _____

Please make checks payable to:
Mountain View Historical Association

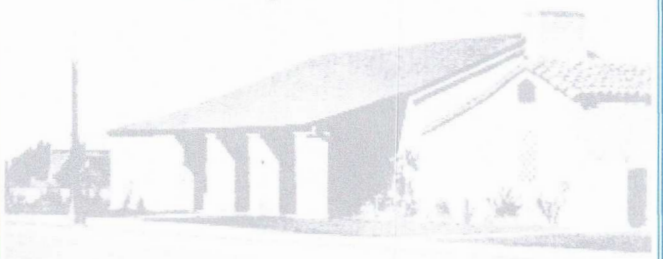
Mail to:
Mountain View Historical Association
PO Box 252, Mountain View, Ca 94042

Spring 2012 Events

SPRING 2012
General Membership Meeting
Sunday, April 29, 2012 at 2PM

Featuring a talk by author Tim Stalney on his book:
The Last of the Prunepickers

See **Page 2** for Details!



At the historic
Adobe Building
157 Moffett Boulevard at Central Expressway
(Parking in the rear off Central Avenue)

May 5-6, 2012
A La Carte & Art Festival*
Castro Street, 10am-6pm
****Seeking volunteers for an MVHA Table - contact Pat Figueroa***

May 20, 2012
Friends of "R" House - Victorian Play Day
Rengstorff House, 2-5pm

June 13, 2012
Board Meeting
Fire Station #4, 6pm

Save the Date:
August 5, 2012
Summer BBQ &
MVHA Membership Meeting
More information in our Summer newsletter!



MOUNTAIN VIEW REVIEW

MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252
Mountain View, Ca 94042

FIRST CLASS MAIL

WEB: *mountainviewhistorical.org*
E-MAIL: *info@mountainviewhistorical.org*

We are now on Facebook!
"Like" us at ***www.facebook.com/MVHistory***
for updates on MVHA Events, historic trivia, and to interact with other members on-line.